Economic History II

School, language and national identity

FGV EPGE

Outline of the class

- What is a nation? **Imagined communities**.
- What is a nation-state? Europe before and after it, and two routes to it.
- The school as the instrument:
  - The making of France (Blanc and Kubo).
- **Backlash**:
  - The headscarf ban in France.

Imagined communities

Benedict Anderson

What is a nation?

- Anderson (1983): the nation as an **imagined** political community.
- Imagined: members will never meet most of their fellow members.
- Limited: finite borders, other nations beyond them. Sovereign: no dynastic realm above it.
- Preconditions he stresses: mass literacy in the vernacular, print capitalism, the end of rule by divine right.
- Nations are recent. They had to be built, and someone had to build them.

BENEDICT ANDERSON



IMAGINED COMMUNITIES

Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism

Imagined community

From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia

"Imagined communities" redirects here. For the book, see Imagined Communities.

An **imagined community** is a concept developed by Benedict Anderson in his 1983 book *Imagined Communities* to analyze nationalism. Anderson depicts a nation as a socially-constructed community, imagined by the people who perceive themselves as part of a group.[1]:6–7

Anderson focuses on the way media creates imagined communities, especially the power of print media in shaping an individual's social psyche. Anderson analyzes the written word, a tool used by churches, authors, and media companies (notably books, newspapers, and magazines), as well as governmental tools such as the map, the census, and the museum. These tools were all built to target and define a mass audience in the public sphere through dominant images, ideologies, and language. Anderson explores the racist and colonial origins of these practices before explaining a general theory that explains how contemporary governments and corporations can (and frequently do) utilize these same practices. These theories were not originally applied to the Internet or television.

Origin [edit]

Historical argument [edit]

According to Anderson's theory of imagined communities, the main historical causes of nationalism include:

- the increasing importance of mass vernacular literacy,
- the movement to abolish the ideas of rule by divine right and hereditary monarchy ("the concept was born in an age in which Enlightenment and Revolution were destroying the legitimacy of the divinely ordained, hierarchical dynastic realm....[N]ations dream of being free...The gage and emblem of this freedom is the sovereign state...", 1991, 7);
- and the emergence of Print capitalism ("the convergence of capitalism and print technology... standardization of national calendars, clocks and language was embodied in books and the publication of daily newspapers")[2]

All of these phenomena coincided with the start of the Industrial Revolution.[2][4]

Nation as an imagined community [edit]

According to Anderson, nations are socially constructed.[5] For Anderson, the idea of the "nation" is relatively new and is a product of various socio-material forces. He defined a nation as "an imagined political community – and imagined as both inherently limited and sovereign".[6] As Anderson puts it, a nation "is imagine

Nation as an imagined community [edit]

According to Anderson, nations are socially constructed.[5] For Anderson, the idea of the "nation" is relatively new and is a product of various socio-material forces. He defined a nation as "an imagined political community – and imagined as both inherently limited and sovereign".[6] As Anderson puts it, a nation "is imagined because the members of even the smallest nation will never know most of their fellow-members, meet them, or even hear of them, yet in the minds of each lives the image of their communion."[6] While members of the community probably will never know each of the other members face to face, they may have similar interests or identify as part of the same nation. Members hold in their minds a mental image of their affinity: for example, the nationhood felt with other members of your nation when your "imagined community" participates in a larger event such as the Olympic Games.

Nations are "limited" in that they have "finite, if elastic boundaries, beyond which lie other nations".[6] They are "sovereign" since no dynastic monarchy can claim authority over them, in the modern period:

> [T]he concept was born in an age in which Enlightenment and Revolution were destroying the legitimacy of the divinely-ordained, hierarchical dynastic realm. Coming to maturity at a stage of human history when even the most devout adherents of any universal religion were inescapably confronted with the living pluralism of such religions, and the allomorphism [incongruence, divide] between each faith's ontological claims and territorial stretch, nations dream of being free, and, if under God, directly so. The gauge and emblem of this freedom is the sovereign state.[6]

Even though we may never see anyone in our imagined community, we still know they are there through communication means such as newspapers. He describes the act of reading a daily paper as a "mass ceremony":

> "It is performed in silent privacy, in the lair of the skull. Yet each communicant is well aware that the ceremony he performs is being replicated simultaneously by thousands (or millions) of others of whose existence he is confident, yet of whose identity he has not the slightest notion." (35)

Finally, a nation is a community because,

> regardless of the actual inequality and exploitation that may prevail in each, the nation is always conceived as a deep, horizontal comradeship. Ultimately it is this fraternity that makes it possible, over the past two centuries, for so many millions of people, not so much to kill, as willingly to die for such limited imaginings.[6]

The nation-state

State, nation, nation-state

- The state (Max Weber, class 8): the monopoly of legitimate force within a territory.
- The nation (Anderson): an imagined community.
- The nation-state: the claim that the two should **coincide**. Gellner (1983, p. 1): nationalism holds that "the political and the national unit should be congruent".

Gellner: why state and nation came to coincide

- Agrarian society: rulers and peasants spoke different languages, and nobody minded.
- Industrial society: a mobile, literate workforce speaking one **standardized language**. Only a state school system can supply it.
- His inversion of Weber: the monopoly of legitimate education now matters more than the monopoly of legitimate violence (*Nations and Nationalism*, 1983, pp. 33-34).

Tilly: two nationalisms

- A principle, not a description: "such large states as France, the United Kingdom, Germany, Italy, and Spain all hosted visibly, vigorously heterogeneous peoples" (Tilly 1994, p. 137).
- State-led: "Rulers who spoke in a nation's name successfully demanded that citizens identify themselves with that nation and subordinate other interests to those of the state."
- State-seeking: "Representatives of some population that currently did not have collective control of a state claimed an autonomous political status, or even a separate state" (p. 133).


EUROPE IN 1815
Monaco Newly created or restored states after the Congress of Vienna
Territorial acquisitions and reacquisitions in brighter colors
Boundary of German Confederation
German small states
Military Frontier against the Ottomans
KINGDOM OF NORWAY
Personal union since 1814
KINGDOM OF SWEDEN
Livonia
Courland
Riga
Dünaburg
Kalmar
Memel
Kovno
Vilna
Minsk
Tilsit
Königsberg
Danzig
Stettin
Bialystok
Pinsk
Warsaw
Posen
Berlin
KINGDOM OF PRUSSIA
KINGDOM OF DENMARK
Copenhagen
Malmö
Bornholm
Helgoland Br. since 1814
Hamburg
Bremen
Lübeck
Kiel
KINGDOM OF HANOVER
KINGDOM OF THE NETHERLANDS
Amsterdam
Brussels
Waterloo
Bologne
Dover
London
Bristol
Cork
Dublin
Glasgow
Edinburgh
York
UNITED KINGDOM OF GREAT BRITAIN AND IRELAND
NORTH SEA
BALTIC SEA
ATLANTIC OCEAN
Leipzig
Kassel
Cologne
Frankfurt
Mainz
KGT. OF SAXON
Dresden
Glogau
KINGDOM OF POLAND
Personal union 1815-32
Congress Poland
Volhynia
Kiev
RUSSIAN EMPIRE
Guernsey
Jersey
Brest
Amiens
Rouen
Paris
Rennes
Nantes
Orléans
Luxembourg
G.D.of Luxemb.
Landau
Nuremberg
Prague
Bohemia
Olmütz
Brünn
Lemberg
Galicia
Brody
Tarnopol
Podolia
Ukraine
Ekaterinoslav
Rep. of Cracow
KGT. OF BAVARIA
KGT. OF WURTEMBERG
Munich
Vienna
Pressburg
Austria
EMPIRE OF AUSTRIA
Bukowina
Moldavia
Bessarabia
Odessa
Kherson
Crimea
Sevastopol
KINGDOM OF FRANCE
Lunéville
Valencay
Bordeaux
Aurillac
Lyons
Basel
Zurich
SWITZ.
Innsbruck
Salzburg
Klagenfurt
Hungary
Transylvania
Temesvar
Agram
Slavonia
Wallachia vassal principality
Bukarest
Silistria
Ismail
Braila
Galatz
Jassy
Trieste
Venice
Milan
Turin
Genevois
Savoy
Nice
Rep. of Lombardo-Venetia
Grand Duchy of Tuscany
Lucca
Parma
Modena
Bologna
Rep. of San Marino
Ancona
Pesaro
Rimini
Ravenna
Florence
Pisa
Leghorn
Elba
Corsica
Ajaccio
Rome
PAPAL STATES
Pontecorvo
Benevento
Naples
Taranto
Otranto
KINGDOM OF THE TWO SICILIES
KINGDOM OF SARDINIA
Cagliari
Palermo
Messina
Malta Br. since 1811
Ionian Islands British protectorate
Corfu
Morea
Athens
Crete
Rhodes
Cyprus
Smyrna
Chios
Lesbos
Adalia
Angora
Bursa
Sinope
Varna
Bulgaria
Sofia
Adrianople
Constantinople
Salonica
Macedonia
Thessaly
Albania
Scutari
Montenegro
Cattaro
Ragusa
Bosnia
Belgrade
Serbia
1815-3817 tributary principality
Nish
OTTOMAN EMPIRE
BLACK SEA
MEDITERRANEAN SEA
KINGDOM OF SPAIN
Oviedo
La Coruña
Burgos
Oporto
Salamanca
Vitoria
Pamplona
Bayonne
Toulouse
Andorra
Rep. of Andorra
Marseilles
Toulon
Zaragoza
Barcelona
Madrid
Toledo
Aranjuez
Lisbon
Badajoz
Valencia
Balearic Islands
Minorca
Majorca
Ibiza
Sevilla
Ballén
Granada
Gibraltar
Tangier
Ceuta
Tetuan de Vélez
Melilla
Cran
Algiers
Bona
Tunis
Fez
MOROCCO
ALGERIA
TUNISIA

Europe in 1815

- After the Congress of Vienna: dynastic states and empires, almost none of them built around a people.
- States without a nation: the Austrian, Russian and Ottoman empires. Tilly: “More states resembled the Austro-Hungarian Empire than emulated Sweden.”
- Nations without a state: Poland partitioned among three empires; Italians and Germans spread over dozens of principalities; Czechs, Hungarians and Croats inside the Habsburg lands.
- The old states did not pass the test either. France in 1794: three million fluent speakers of French out of twenty-nine million inhabitants, by Grégoire’s count.

Map: Alexander Altenhof, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0.



The ethnic groups of Austria-Hungary in 1910 according to *Distribution of Races in Austria-Hungary* by William R. Shepherd, 1911.

Austria-Hungary: one state, ten peoples

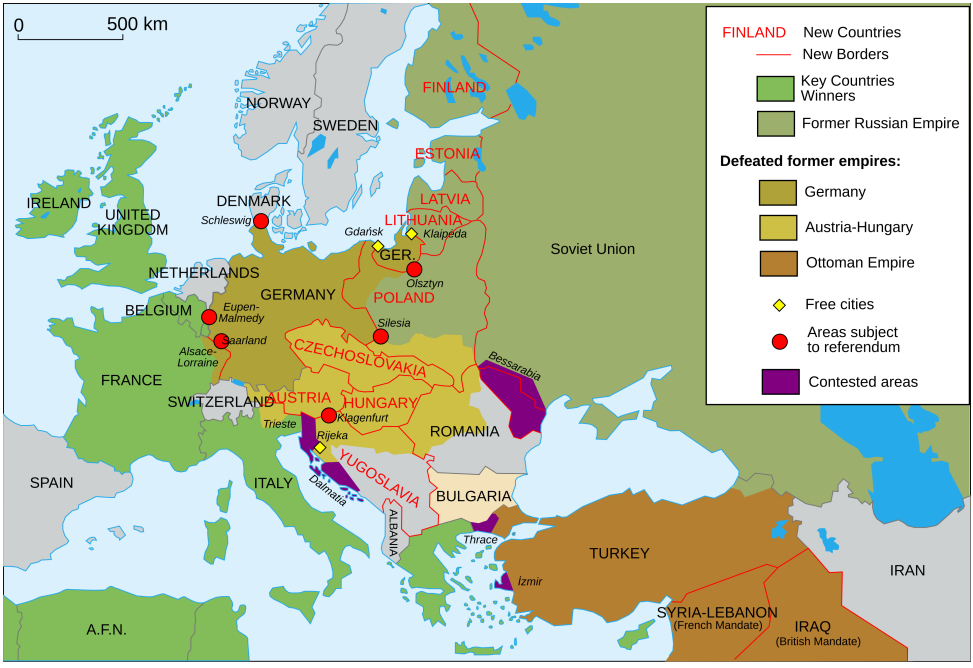
- Germans, Hungarians, Czechs, Slovaks, Poles, Ukrainians, Slovenes, Croats and Serbs, Romanians, Italians. Germans about a quarter of the population in 1910, Hungarians about a fifth, nobody a majority.
- Since the Compromise of 1867 two states, one emperor, two parliaments, one army.
- The Hungarian half tried the French route: **Magyarization**, Hungarian imposed in schools and administration from the 1870s. It alienated Slovaks, Romanians and Croats rather than absorbing them.
- The Austrian half gave up on a single language. A decree putting Czech on a par with German in the Bohemian administration brought down the government in 1897.


Distribution of Races in Former Austria-Hungary.*
Germans
Magyars
Rumanians
Croats and Servians
Ruthenians
Czechs
Slovaks
Poles
Slovenes
Italians
Scale 1:7 500 000
Miles
Slavs
GERMAN EMPIRE
RUSSIA
BOHEMIA
MORAVIA
GALICIA
UPPER AUSTRIA
LOWER AUSTRIA
Vienna
Budapest
HUNGARY
TYROL
CARNIOLA
CROATIA-SLAVONIA
BOSNIA
HERZEGOVINA
DALMATIA
MONTENEGRO
ALBANIA
TRANSYLVANIA
BUKOWINA
BULGARIA
SERVIA
ITALY
SWITZERLAND
ADRIATIC SEA
Bucharest
Sofia
Belgrade
Prague
Munich
Trieste
Venice
Zara
Ragusa
Scutari
Salonica
Constantinople
Long. East of Greenwich
* The basis of the map is the situation in 1914. Territorial changes in 1920 are indicated in red.

The same map with the 1920 borders in red

- The empire replaced by Austria, Hungary, Czechoslovakia and the Kingdom of Serbs, Croats and Slovenes, with pieces to Poland, Romania and Italy.
- Borders drawn around peoples where possible. Often it was not: the German-speaking fringe of Bohemia went to Czechoslovakia, the Hungarian pockets of Transylvania to Romania, South Tyrol to Italy.
- Every successor state had large **minorities**. The German fringe of Bohemia is the Sudetenland question of 1938.
- Self-determination produced new mismatches rather than ending them.

Map: Shepherd, Historical Atlas (1911), with the 1920 changes added in red. Public domain.


0
500 km
FINLAND New Countries
New Borders
Key Countries Winners
Former Russian Empire
Defeated former empires:
Germany
Austria-Hungary
Ottoman Empire
Free cities
Areas subject to referendum
Contested areas
NORWAY
SWEDEN
FINLAND
ESTONIA
LATVIA
LITHUANIA
Klaipeda
Gdańsk
GER
Olsztyn
POLAND
Silesia
Soviet Union
IRELAND
UNITED KINGDOM
DENMARK
Schleswig
NETHERLANDS
GERMANY
BELGIUM
Eupen-Malmedy
Saarland
Alsace-Lorraine
FRANCE
SWITZERLAND
CZECHOSLOVAKIA
Bessarabia
AUSTRIA
HUNGARY
Klagenfurt
Trieste
Rijeka
ROMANIA
SPAIN
ITALY
YUGOSLAVIA
Dalmatia
BULGARIA
ALBANIA
Thrace
İzmir
TURKEY
IRAN
SYRIA-LEBANON
(French Mandate)
IRAQ
(British Mandate)
A.F.N.

Europe in 1923

- Four empires gone: Habsburg, Romanov, Hohenzollern, Ottoman. New or restored states in red, from Finland to Yugoslavia.
- Wilson's principle of **self-determination**: borders around peoples, plebiscites where it was unclear which people a region belonged to.
- The League of Nations imposed minority treaties on the new states. The borders had not solved the problem.
- The cleanest nation-states on the map are the rump states, Austria and Hungary, almost monolingual. Not by nation building, but by having lost everything else.

Map: Fluteflute and Historicair, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 2.5.

Two routes to congruence

- Move the borders to fit the people, Tilly's state-seeking nationalism: the Habsburg successor states of 1920, rump Austria and Hungary above all.
- Remake the people to fit the borders, state-led nationalism: **France**. Borders largely in place by the eighteenth century; the nation built inside them by schools, conscription, roads and railways (Eugen Weber).
- Most cases sit in between. Italy: borders moved in 1861 around a nation that spoke Italian mainly in Tuscany and Rome, about 2.5 percent of the population by De Mauro's count, about 10 percent by Castellani's. Then a century of the French route. Germany likewise.
- Yugoslavia and Czechoslovakia: products of the first route that attempted the second, and broke apart in the 1990s.

Nation building

Making citizens

- Nineteenth century: policies of **homogenization** and assimilation advanced social cohesion and political stability, at the expense of diversity.
- Napoleon, 1805: "There cannot be a firmly established political state unless there is a teaching body with definitely recognized principles. If the child is not taught from infancy that he ought to be a republican or a monarchist, a Catholic or a free-thinker, the state will not constitute a nation; it will rest on uncertain and shifting foundations; and it will be constantly exposed to disorder and change."
- After Italian unification, d'Azeglio: Italy has been made, Italians still have to be.
- Alesina, Giuliano and Reich: the threat of democratization or civil conflict is the strongest determinant of homogenization.

Nation-Building and Education

Alberto Alesina, Paola Giuliano & Bryony Reich

Nations stay together when citizens share enough values and preferences and can communicate with each other. Democracies and dictatorships have different incentives when it comes to choosing how much and by what means to homogenize the population, i.e. “to build a nation”. We study and compare nation-building policies under the transition from dictatorship to democracy in a model where the location and type of government and the borders of the country are endogenous. We find that the threat of democratization provides the strongest incentive to homogenize. We focus upon a specific nation-building policy: the provision of mass primary education. As a motivation, we offer historical discussions of several episodes in the nineteenth century and suggestive correlations for a large sample of countries over the 1925-2014 period.

> *"There cannot be a firmly established political state unless there is a teaching body with definitely recognized principles. If the child is not taught from infancy that he ought to be a republican or a monarchist, a Catholic or a free-thinker, the state will not constitute a nation; it will rest on uncertain and shifting foundations; and it will be constantly exposed to disorder and change."* Napoleon I, 1805[1]

In 1860 French was still a foreign language to half of all French children.[2] Outside major cities, France was a country of different languages, dialects and diverse currencies.[3] Travel far outside one's own village was rare, and indifference or hostility to the French state common.[4] From the French Revolution and throughout the 19th century, French rulers expressed the imperative "to form French citizens".[5] Following the unification of Italy (1860), a process led by a Northern elite which then ruled the country, Massimo d'Azeglio (one of the founders of unified Italy) famously remarked: "Italy has been made; now it remains to make Italians." In

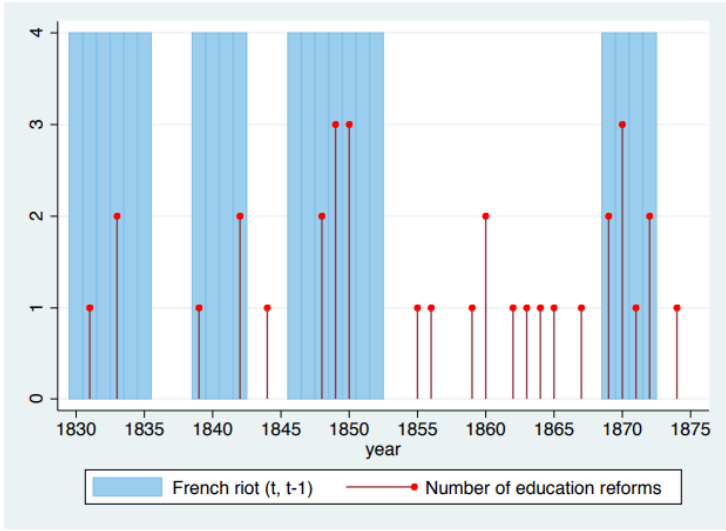


Figure 2: Years of major rioting in France and number of education reforms across Europe

Curriculum as nation building, still

- Argentina: the **Malvinas** taught as a school subject, with an official teaching kit, classroom posters, and a march learned by heart.
- United States: the Pledge of Allegiance recited in school.
- Brazil: schools required to sing the national anthem, and a calendar of civic dates.
- Brazil, 1938: Vargas's Campanha de Nacionalização, the nationalization campaign, closed foreign-language schools, mostly German and Italian ones in the south, and made Portuguese the only language of instruction.
- In every case the content is chosen centrally and the school is where it is delivered.



2 de abril

Malvinas en la escuela

Presentamos una selección de producciones elaboradas por el Programa Educación y Memoria para abordar la enseñanza de Malvinas. Este material —que invita a reflexionar en el marco de la memoria, la soberanía y la democracia— constituye un aporte para el trabajo de docentes y estudiantes de las escuelas de todo el país.



Más recursos

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- Programas Canal Encuentro
- Literatura y Malvinas

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Marcha de las Malvinas

Tras su manto de neblinas,
no las hemos de olvidar,
"Las Malvinas Argentinas",
clama el viento y ruge el mar.

Ni de aquellos horizontes
nuestra enseña han de arrancar,
pues su blanco está en los montes
y en su azul se tiñe el mar.

Por ausente, por vencido
bajo extraño pabellón,
ningún suelo más querido,
de la patria en la extensión.

¿Quién nos habla aquí de olvido,
de renuncia o de perdón?
Ningún suelo más querido,
de la patria en la extensión.

Rompa el manto de neblinas,
como un sol, nuestro ideal:
"Las Malvinas Argentinas
en dominio ya inmortal".

Y ante el sol de nuestro emblema,
pura, nítida y triunfal,
brille, oh, Patria, en tu diadema,
la perdida perla austral.

¡Para honor de nuestro emblema
para orgullo nacional,
brille, oh, Patria, en tu diadema,
la perdida perla austral.

Para honor de nuestro emblema
para orgullo nacional
Brille, oh, Patria, en tu diadema,
la perdida perla austral.

Eisenhower.[14][15]

Recital [edit]

Congressional sessions open with the recital of the Pledge, as do many government meetings at local levels, and meetings held by many private organizations. All states except Nebraska, Hawaii, Vermont, and Wyoming require a regularly scheduled recitation of the pledge in public schools.[13] Many states give a variety of exemptions from reciting the pledge, such as California which requires a "patriotic exercise" every day, which would be satisfied by the Pledge, but it is not enforced.[14] The Supreme Court has ruled in *West Virginia State Board of Education v. Barnette* that students cannot be compelled to recite the Pledge, nor can they be punished for not doing so.[15] In several states, state flag pledges of allegiance are required to be recited after the pledge to the American flag.[16]

The current United States Flag Code says:

> The Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag: "I pledge allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America, and to the Republic for which it stands, one Nation under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all," should be rendered by standing at attention facing the flag with the right hand over the heart. When not in uniform, men should remove any non-religious headdress with their right hand and hold it at the left shoulder, the hand being over the heart. Persons in uniform should remain silent, face the flag, and render the military salute.[17] Members of the Armed Forces not in uniform and veterans may render the military salute in the manner provided for persons in uniform.[4]

1954 (current version, per 4 U.S.C. §4)[4]

"I pledge allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America, and to the Republic for which it stands, one nation **under God**, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all."



School children in 1899 reciting the Pledge of Allegiance



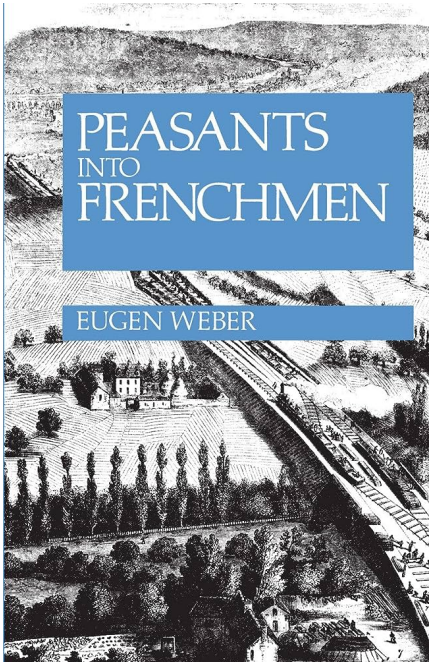
Students recite the Pledge of Allegiance at Hayesville High School in 2004

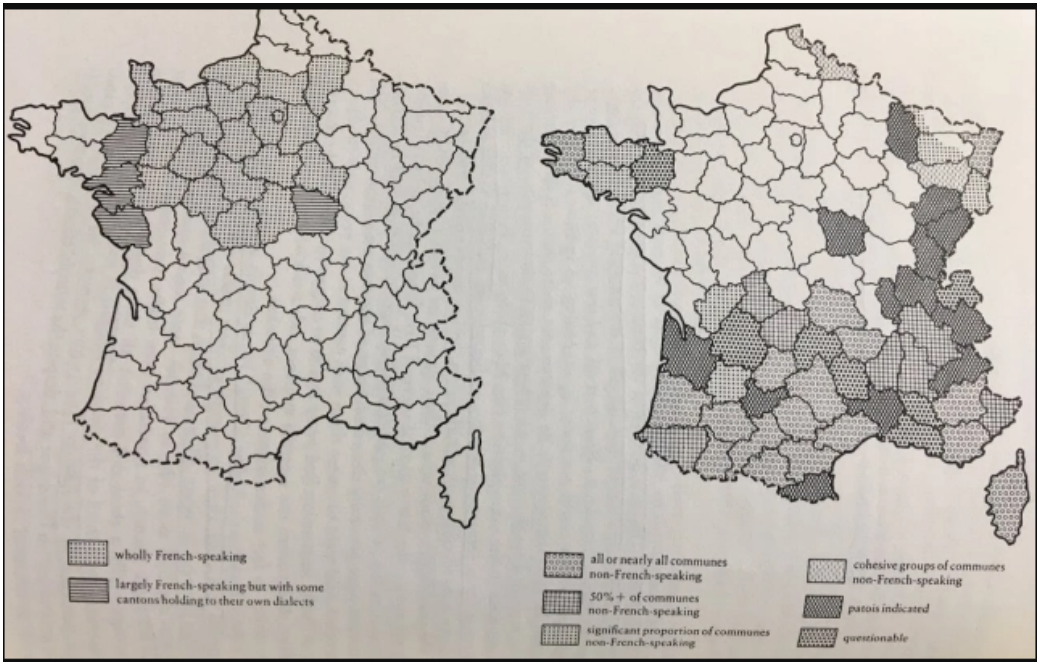
Origins [edit]

Historians point to surges in American patriotic oaths and pledges to the flag after the Civil

Peasants into Frenchmen

- Eugen **Weber** (1976): France became a nation late, through schools, roads, railways and conscription.
- "The Third Republic found a France in which French was a foreign language for half the citizens" (Weber, 1976, p. 70).
- Blanc and Kubo move the turning point earlier: to the Guizot Law of 1833, not the Ferry Laws of 1881 and 1882.


PEASANTS
INTO
FRENCHMEN
EUGEN WEBER


wholly French-speaking
largely French-speaking but with some cantons holding to their own dialects
all or nearly all communes non-French-speaking
50% + of communes non-French-speaking
significant proportion of communes non-French-speaking
cohesive groups of communes non-French-speaking
patois indicated
questionable

The making of France

Blanc and Kubo

The Making of France

Guillaume Blanc and Masahiro Kubo*

February 11, 2026

Link to the latest version

Abstract

This paper studies nation-building in a fragmented society. We document the political economy of mass education, the adoption of a common language, and the construction of a national identity in France. Using a regression discontinuity design, we show that state-sponsored education led to linguistic homogenization. To understand why nation-building was successful, we study heterogeneity and find that knowledge elites and the demand for education were instrumental.

JEL codes: $P00, H52, I25, N33, Z13, D72$
Keywords: *nation-building, language, mass education, institutions*

France before French

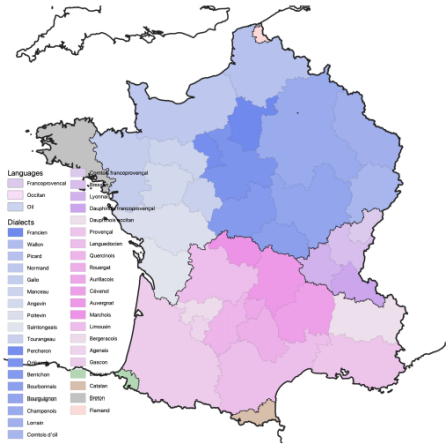
- More than forty languages and dialects spoken historically: the **langues d'oïl** in the north, the *lenga d'òc* (Occitan) in the south, plus Breton, Basque, Alsatian, Catalan, Flemish.
- Occitan was largely unintelligible to speakers of the langues d'oïl, and closest to Catalan.
- It was the language of the troubadours. Dante counted *oc* as one of three families of vernacular Romance.
- Grégoire (1794): "we are still, for language, the Tower of Babel". He counted three million fluent speakers of French out of twenty-nine million inhabitants.

Three centuries of decrees, little effect

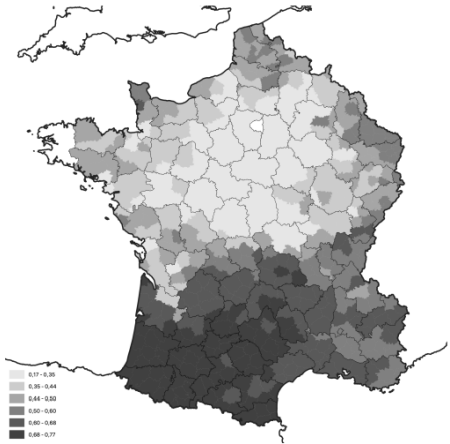
- Villers-Cotterêts, 1539: French required in legal documents, parish records, contracts. Other tongues relegated to spoken use.
- Its real target was Latin, not the dialects. Local speech was virtually unaffected.
- Revolutionary projects for universal schooling (Talleyrand, Condorcet): none carried to its term.
- Today French is the only recognized official language and most of the other tongues are endangered.

Figure 3: Historical language regions and linguistic distance from French in 1900

Note: This figure displays the spatial distribution of historical languages and dialects (Panel A) and linguistic distance from French in 1900 (Panel B). Linguistic distance from French is defined as the Levenshtein distance from Le Plessis-Robinson. Observations are at the municipality level, but, to ease readability, we generate Thiessen polygons around each town surveyed in the *Atlas* to plot our measure. Sources: Billy, Nadiras and Moufflet (n.d.) for historical language regions, Gilliéron and Edmont (1902-1910) and authors' calculations for linguistic distance from French.



(Panel A) Historical language regions



(Panel B) Linguistic distance from French (1900)

Reading the map

- Left: historical language regions. Right: how far each village's speech sat from French in 1900.
- Darker means **farther** from French: the whole Occitan south, and the peripheries generally.
- The 1900 measure still traces the old regions, so it picks up deep-rooted differences as well as recent change.

Figure 1: Mirèio (1859), Frédéric Mistral

Note: This figure displays the first page of the poem "Mirèio" in Provençal (Panel A) and in French (Panel B). Source: gallica.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/bpt6k7490v.

MIRÈIO

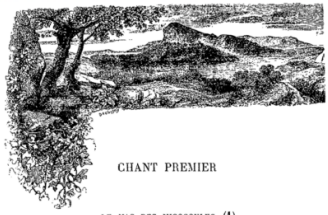
CANT PROUMIÈ

LOU MAS DI FALABREGO.

Cante uno chato de Prouvènço
Dins lis amour de sa jouvènço,
A travès de la Crau, vers la mar, dins li bla,
Umble escoulan dóu grand Oumèro,
Ieu la vole segui. Coume èro
Rèn qu'uno chato de la terro,
En foro de la Crau se n'es gaire parla.

Emai soun front noun lusiguèsse
Que de jouinesso; emai n'aguèsse
Ni diadèmo d'or ni mantèu de Damas,
Vole qu'en glòri fugue aussado
Coume uno rèino, e caressado
Pèr nosto lengo mespresado,
Car cantan que pèr vautre, o pastre e gènt di mas!

(Panel A) Provençal



CHANT PREMIER

LE MAS DES MICOCOULES. (1)

Je chante une jeune fille de Provence. — Dans les amours de sa jeunesse, — à travers la Crau (2), vers la mer, dans les blés, — humble écolier du grand Homère, — je veux la suivre. Comme c'était — seulement une fille de la glèbe, — en dehors de la Crau il s'en est peu parlé.

Bien que son front ne brillât — que de jeunesse; bien qu'elle n'eût — ni diadème d'or ni manteau de Damas, — je veux qu'en gloire elle soit élevée — comme une reine, et caressée — par notre langue méprisée, — car nous ne chantons que pour vous, ô pâtres et habitants des *mas*.

(Panel B) French

Figure A4: Street names

Note: This figure displays street names in Alsacien (Panel A) and Provençal (Panel B) dialects. Sources: Wikipedia.



(Panel A) Alsacien



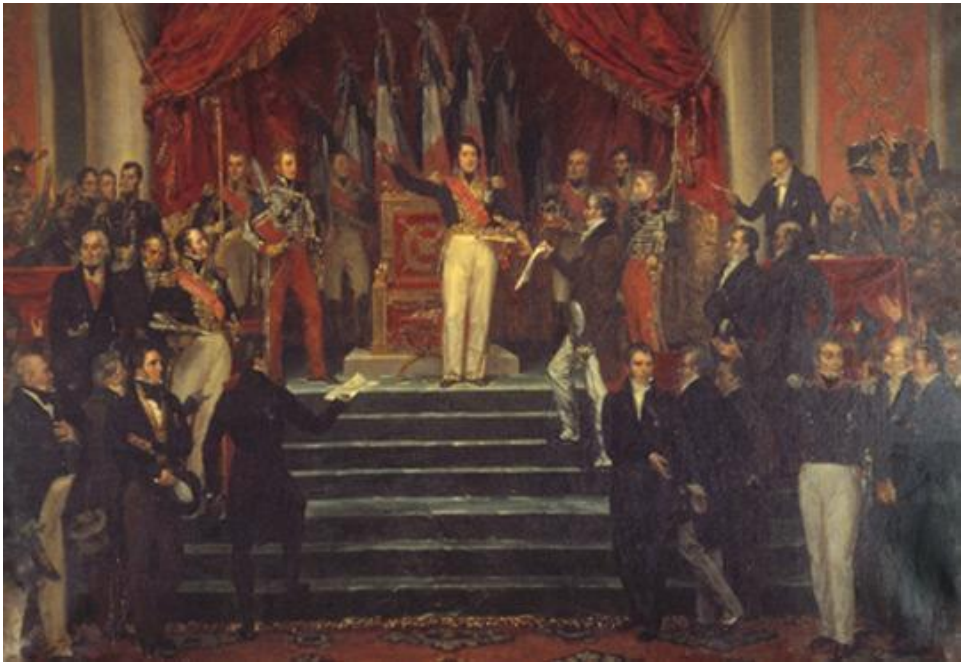
(Panel B) Provençal

The question

- How does a state turn a fragmented society into a nation with a common language and a common identity?
- Blanc and Kubo study the **public school** as the instrument: instruction in and of French, national history, state-approved textbooks, state-trained teachers.
- And they ask why the policy took hold in some places and not in others.

Two laws of the July Monarchy

- **Municipal Law of 1831**: local elections for the first time. Above 500 inhabitants, relatives were barred from sitting together on the council, and the council grew from 10 to 12 members.
- **Guizot Law of 1833**: every municipality to have a primary school for boys, a state-designed curriculum, state textbooks, teachers trained in new departmental normal schools, inspectors and committees to enforce it.
- The Guizot Law was funded and implemented by the municipal councils. Local willingness decided.

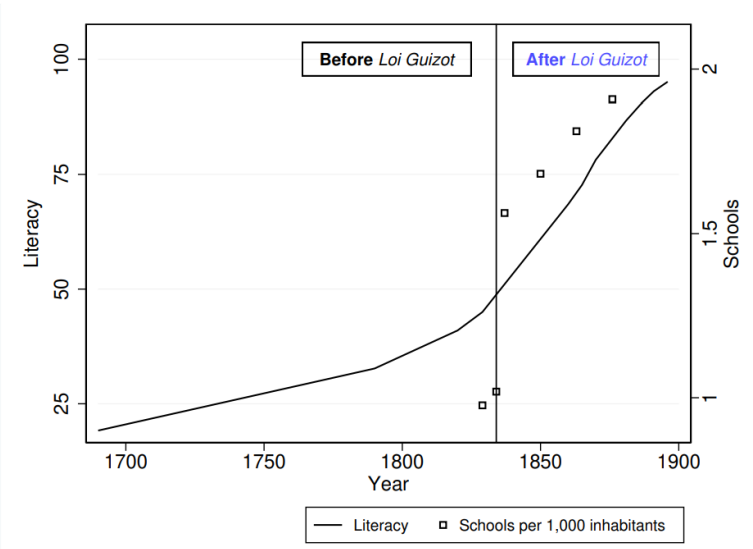


What the school was for

- Guizot (1833): “through the teaching of the French language, primary schools will instill and spread the spirit and unity of nationality everywhere”.
- A close advisor described each school as “a colony of French language in a conquered land” (Lorain, 1837).
- Before the law most teachers were clergy, or, in Weber’s list, “a retired soldier, a rural constable, the local barber, innkeeper, or grocer, or simply a half-educated peasant’s son”.
- The number of primary schools nearly doubled within a decade, and **universal literacy** followed.

Figure 4: Literacy and schools

Note: This figure displays the literacy rate (left) and number of primary schools per thousand inhabitants (right) ov time in France. Source: Statistique Générale de la France (n.d.*a*).



The law was not applied everywhere

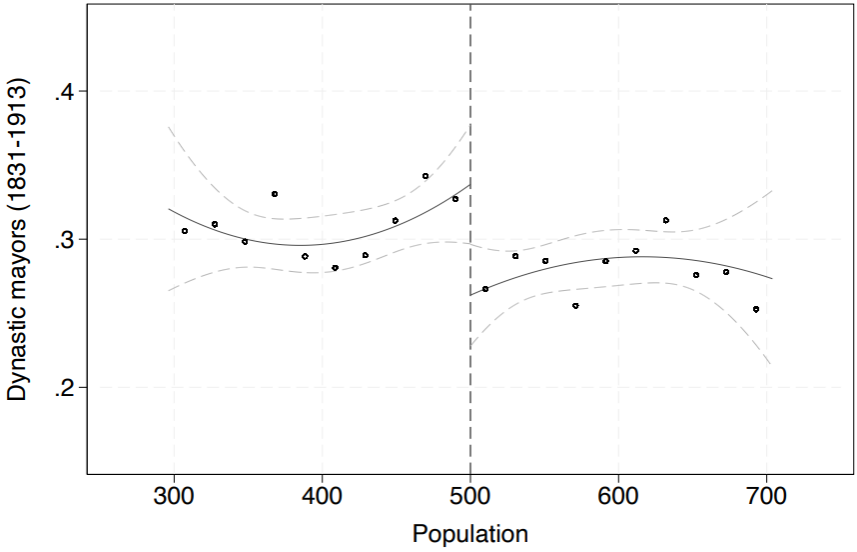
- Guizot to the National Assembly, 1834: “there are 21,000 municipalities in France that do not feel the need for primary instruction or that do not dare to do what it takes to satisfy this need”.
- Historians have long described the Guizot Law as applying above **500 inhabitants**, and departmental archives repeat the figure.
- But no such threshold appears in the text of the law or in any later decree.
- What did change at 500 was the Municipal Law: who was allowed to sit on the council.

The comparison

- Compare municipalities **just above** 500 inhabitants in the 1830s with those just below.
- Nothing else jumps at 500: altitude, ruggedness, distance to the coast, roads, market access, industrial establishments, Encyclopédie subscriptions, Napoleonic conscription, cadaster.
- No pile-up of villages just above the line, and no selective migration after the laws.
- Rural municipalities only, where 80.7 percent of the French population lived in 1836.

The council of families

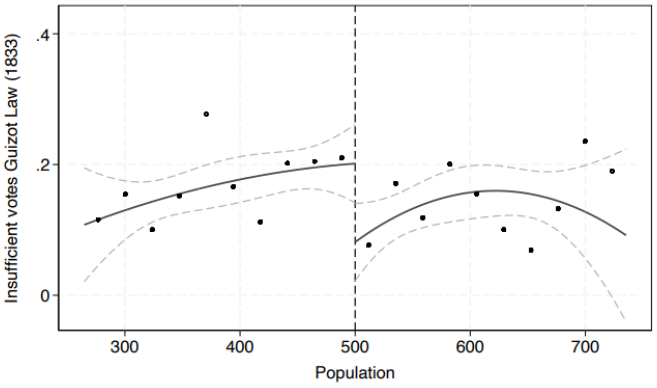
- Before 1831, small villages were run by a handful of related families. **Nepotism** and clientelism were the norm, especially after the Bourbon Restoration.
- The prefect of Aube, 1835: “The voters appoint themselves members of the municipal council; they are rarely able to read or write; they are all relatives or allies”.
- Landed elites had little use for schooling, a portable asset worth little to a landowner.
- Where they were removed, bourgeois notables came in, and they wanted schools.



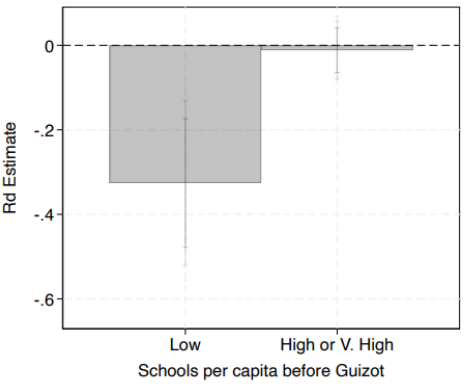
(Panel A) RD plot

The dynasties weakened

- Data: a crowdsourced genealogy site listing French mayors since the Revolution, about **248,000** names, cleaned and restricted to well documented municipalities.
- A mayor counts as dynastic if he shares a surname with a mayor from before 1831 in the same village.
- Above 500: about 10 percentage points less likely to have a dynastic mayor, against a base of about 30 percent below.
- Right after the Municipal Law the gap reaches nearly 20 percentage points, and it is driven entirely by the Bourbon families.



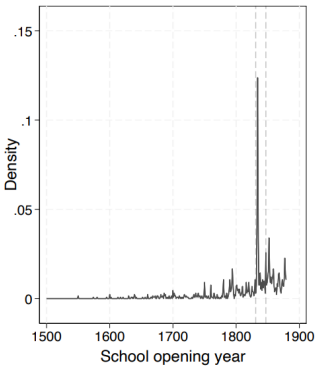
(Panel A) RD plot



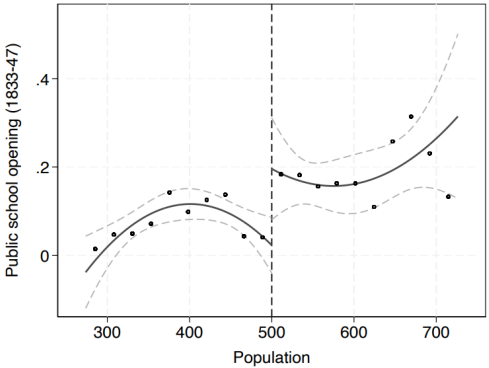
(Panel B) Heterogeneity: school density before

The vote of 1833

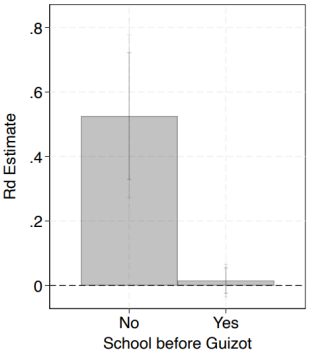
- After the Guizot Law passed, councils had to deliberate on funding it. Prefects tabulated who voted **insufficient** taxes, or refused any new tax at all.
- Archival work in seven departments, north and south, covering close to three thousand municipalities.
- Above 500, insufficient votes were roughly cut in half.
- The gap is largest where there were fewest schools before, that is, where a school had to be built from nothing.



(Panel A) Time series



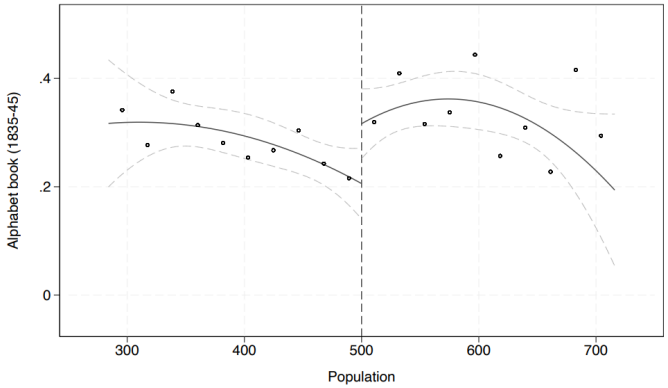
(Panel B) RD plot



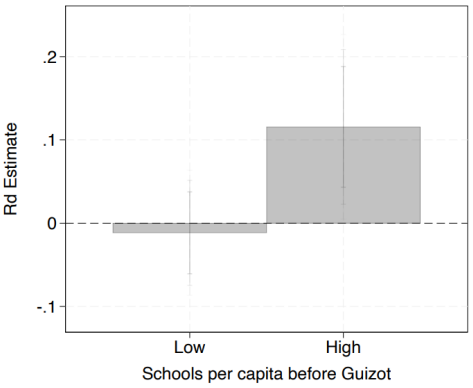
(Panel C) Heterogeneity: school before

Schools built

- Prefects in 1879 listed the opening date of every school in their jurisdiction. Openings jump right after 1833, by far the largest break in three centuries of records.
- Above 500, municipalities were much more likely to open a public school for boys or girls between 1833 and 1847.
- Among villages with **no school at all** before, the jump is about 60 percentage points.
- Secular schools and boys' schools, not religious ones: removing the landed elites also weakened the Church's hold on primary education.



(Panel A) RD plot



(Panel B) Heterogeneity: school density before

What was taught

- The *Alphabet et premier livre de lecture*: the approved French reader, one million copies sent to schools within three years of the law.
- It taught standardized French together with lessons in conduct, obedience and morality, and put the other languages of France in second place.
- Above 500, schools were more likely to have it. No comparable jump for history books or the Bible, which took longer to write and distribute.
- Teachers: three normal schools in France in 1828, seventy-two by 1834, and a certificate exam built around written French and spelling.

Measuring the language of a village

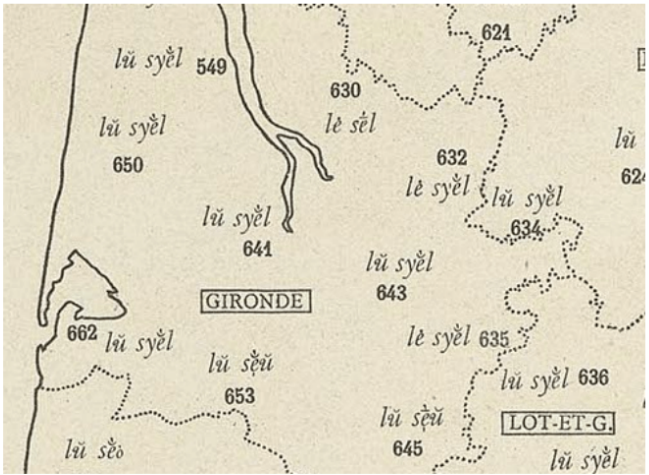
- **Atlas Linguistique de la France**: from 1897 to 1901 Edmont traveled the country asking locals the common pronunciation of 1,920 words and expressions in 577 municipalities.
- One printed map per word (for example *ciel*, "sky"). Only spontaneous replies were recorded, and the aim was the average speech of the village, not of one person.
- Distance from French: compare the phonetic spelling of 50 everyday words (cat, dog, rain, water, sky, night) with the surveyed town closest to Paris.
- Timing is convenient: most adults in 1900 predate the Ferry Laws and the railway plan.

Figure 2: Map of *ciel* (“sky”)

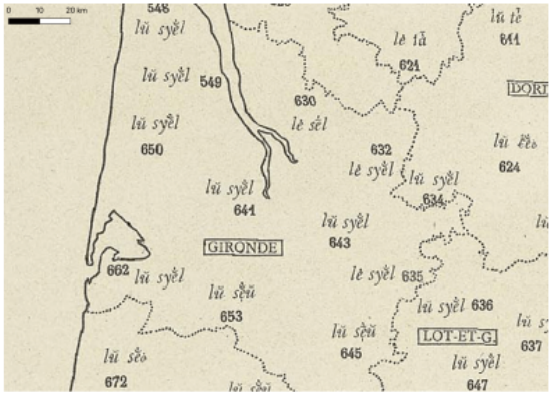
Note: This figure displays a map from the *Atlas Linguistique de la France* (Gilliéron and Edmont, 1902-1910) showing the pronunciation of *ciel* (“sky”) across municipalities in France (Panel A) and in the southern part of France only (Panel B). The map displays *le ciel* (“the sky”), but we only digitized the word “sky.”



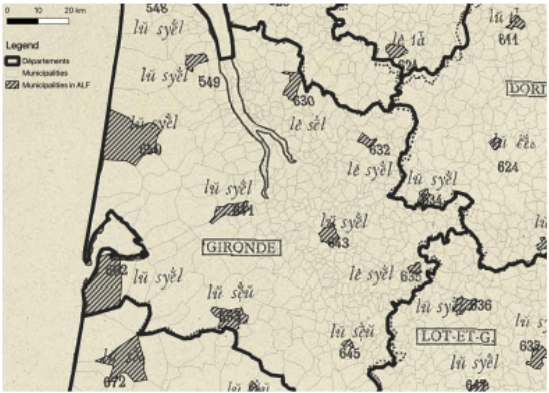
(Panel A) France



(Panel B) Zoomed in



(Panel A) Map of *ciel* ("sky")



(Panel B) With municipalities

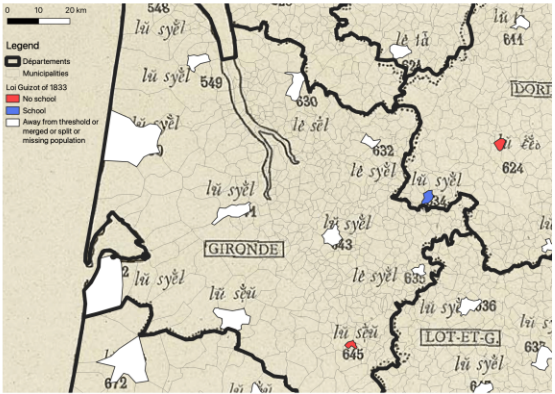
Table 1: Digitized maps (words) from the Swadesh list in the *Atlas*

Note: This table displays the words (or maps) that we have digitized from the *Atlas Linguistique de la France*. We also report the corresponding map number in the *Atlas* for each word.

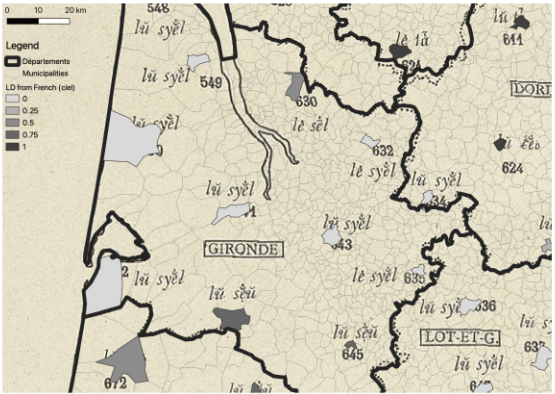
Maps of the *Atlas Linguistique de la France*									
43	animal	142	drink	796	hand	923	new	1241	sun
210	ashes	946	ear	314	how	929	night	894	swim
1	bee	1299	earth	638	knee	908	nose	1120	tail
916	black	558	fire	1200	know	76	others	233	to sing
1187	blood	1052	fish	559	leaf	1039	rain	344	to spit
250	cat	582	flowers	120	lots	1159	river	750	tongue
461	child	178	fog	788	moon	285	sky	52	trees
612	cold	615	fruit	874	mountain	418	sleep	397	two
882	die	1031	full	151	mouth	494	star	432	water
279	dog	270	hair	328	neck	1014	stone	594	wood

One corner of Gironde

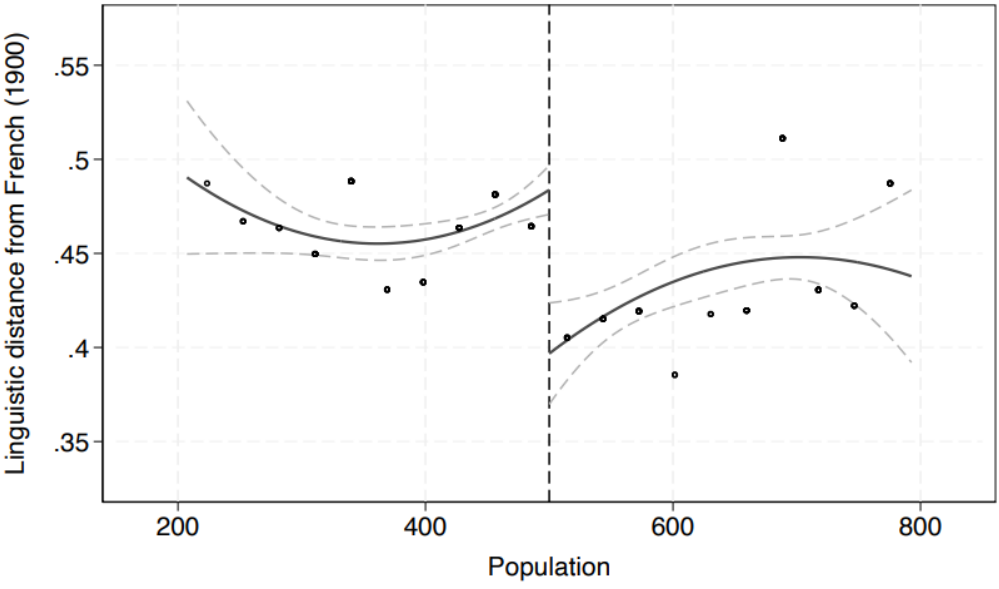
- Same map, twice: which villages were above the threshold when the Guizot Law came in, and how far each one's speech sat from French.
- Neighboring villages a few miles apart said *ciel*, *cel* or *ceu*.
- Moving from *ceu* to *ciel* changes both the **word** and the vowel.



(Panel D) With treatment status after *Loi Guizot* (state-sponsored education)

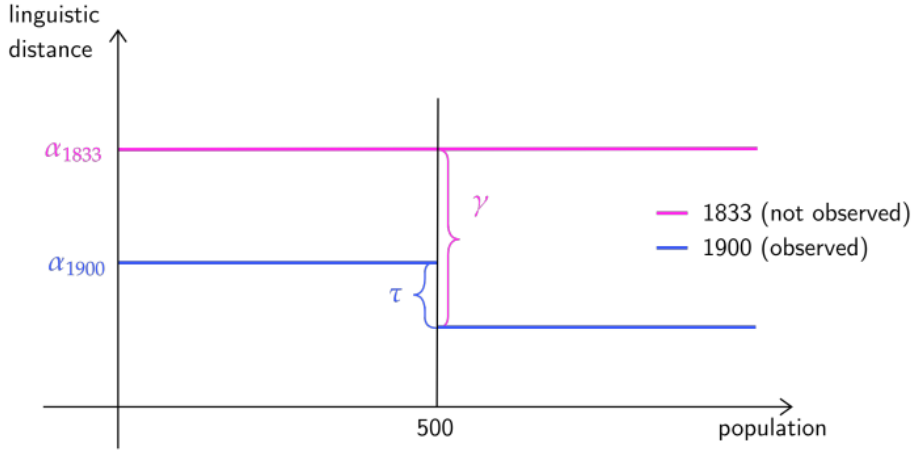


(Panel E) Linguistic distance from French (*ciel*)


Linguistic distance from French (1900)
.55
.5
.45
.4
.35
200
400
600
800
Population

Schooling moved everyday speech toward French

- Distance from French in 1900 falls by about **0.10** at the threshold, on a scale running from zero to one.
- That is roughly 20 percent of what the distance would otherwise have been, and more than a third of the median gap between the Occitan and the oïl regions.
- The Atlas recorded the speech of the village, not the speech of the classroom. So this is French adopted in daily life.
- Villages near the threshold are underrepresented in the south, where distance was greatest, so the estimate is if anything too small.



$$|\mathbf{g}| \equiv |\gamma| / \alpha_{1833}$$
$$0 \leq |\tau| / \alpha_{1900} \leq |\mathbf{g}|$$

How fast did it happen

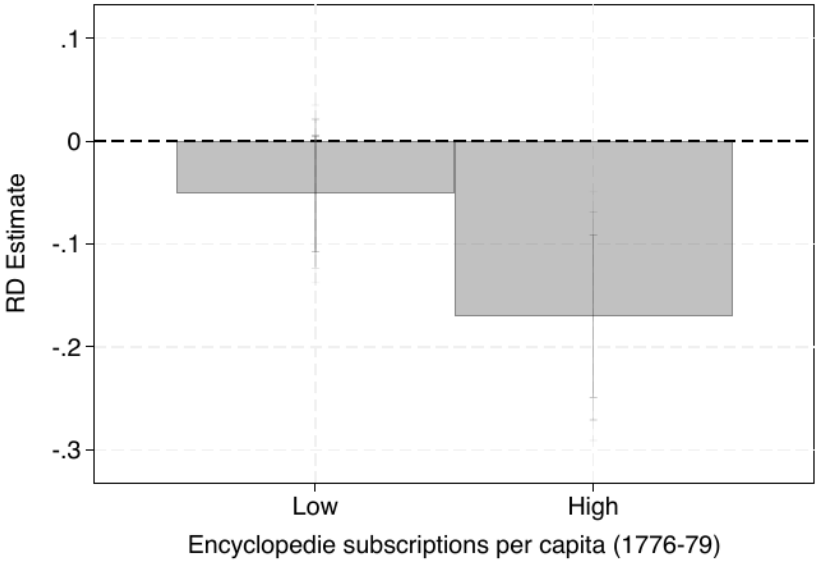
- Only one snapshot of language exists, 1900. Nobody surveyed village speech in 1833.
- If schooling pushed in the same direction as the overall drift of the century, the gap visible in 1900 is a **floor** on how fast homogenization ran.
- Reading: distance from French fell by at least 20 percent between 1833 and 1900 at the threshold.

Whose French

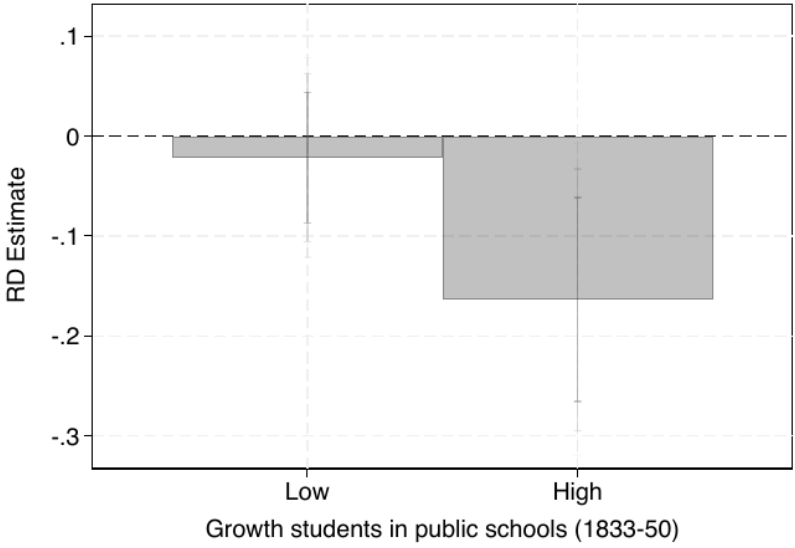
- Redo the comparison using each surveyed town in turn as the reference point for "French".
- Villages above the threshold moved toward the speech of the **Paris Basin and the Loire Valley**, above all Touraine and Anjou. Not toward peripheral languages.
- Paris supplied the Francien dialect; the Loire hosted the royal court in the Renaissance; Anjou was the seat of the Angevin dynasty.
- The school spread the language of the elites, and this doubles as a check on the design.

Vocabulary in the south, accent in the north

- In the historically Occitan south, villages above the threshold used **30 percentage points** more French words. In the north, no change in vocabulary.
- In the north what moves instead is pronunciation: a gradual drift of dialects toward the common language.
- Distance falls by about 8 percent in the oïl region and about 30 percent in the Occitan region.
- The south is where the identity cost of switching was highest, and it switched most.



(Panel A) Knowledge elites



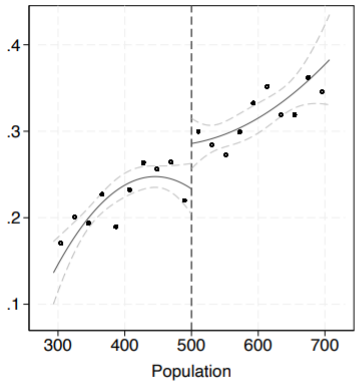
(Panel C) Educational demand

Where the policy worked

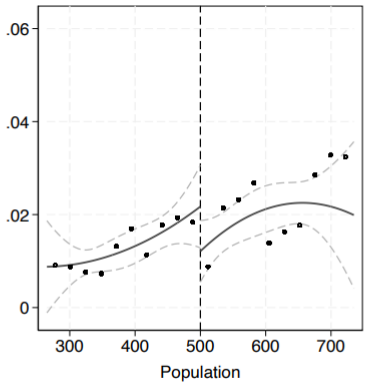
- Larger where **knowledge elites** were present, proxied by subscriptions to the Encyclopédie before the Revolution.
- Larger where the number of students in public schools grew fastest after 1833, and where railways later expanded.
- The same across levels of income per capita, so this is not simply the richer places.
- Guizot did not make attendance compulsory. Families had to want the school, and schooling also supplied reading, writing and arithmetic.

What would have broken the story

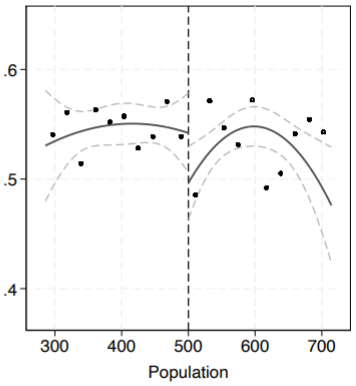
- Move the cutoff anywhere between 300 and 700 inhabitants: no jump.
- Measure population in other years of the century: no jump, except around 1831 and 1836.
- Across more than 400 such false tests, fewer than 9 percent produce a detectable break, against over 96 percent at 500 inhabitants in 1831 or 1836.
- No jump at 500 in cadasters, post offices, roads or railways. The change in council composition moved **schooling**, not public goods in general.



(Panel A) Resistance heroes (WWII)



(Panel B) Nazi collaborators (WWII)



(Panel C) Regionalization (1969)

The long run

- Above the threshold, villages were more likely to be the birthplace of someone awarded the Médaille de la Résistance for "remarkable acts of faith and courage that contributed to the resistance of the French people against the enemy".
- Less likely to be the birthplace of men who joined the Gestapo, the German Intelligence Service or the Waffen-SS.
- In the 1969 referendum, support for handing power back to the regions was about 5 percentage points lower. Nationally the referendum was rejected by 52.4 percent.
- The **Resistance** result is the firm one; collaboration and the referendum are suggestive, since collaborators are rare.

Takeaway

- France **assimilated**. The paper documents successful nation building, not backlash.
- Coercion alone did not do it. Local power had to shift first, and families had to want what the school offered.
- Nation building took hold as the returns to human capital rose, in the transition out of stagnation.
- Question for what follows: what happens when the state bans a marker of identity instead of supplying a new one?

Backlash: the headscarf ban in France

The same question, today

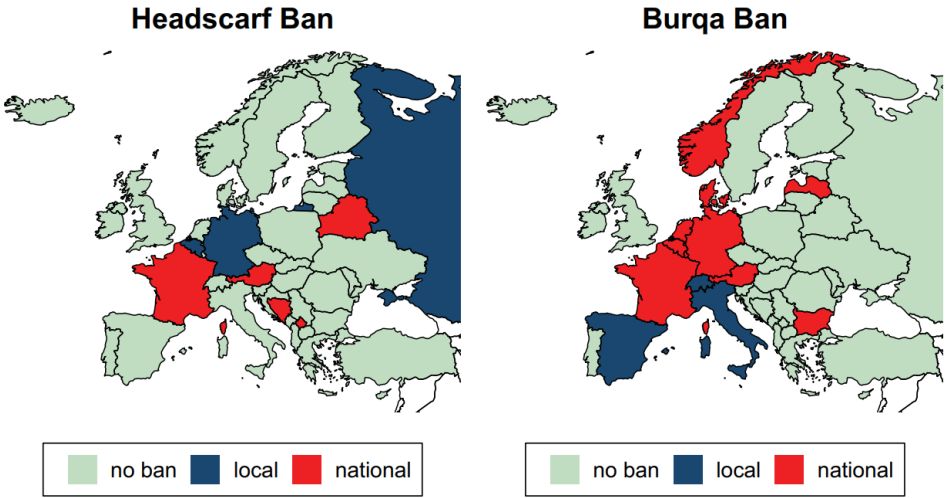
- Abdelgadir and Fouka: France barred conspicuous religious symbols from public schools, the **headscarf** among them.
- Muslim girls exposed to the ban completed secondary school less often, with knock-on effects on work and on family formation.
- Reported experience of racism at school rises, trust in French school falls.
- Both identities strengthen: they feel more French, and more attached to the father's country of origin.

Political Secularism and Muslim Integration in the West: Assessing the Effects of the French Headscarf Ban

AALA ABDELGADIR *Stanford University*
VASILIKI FOUKA *Stanford University*

In response to rising immigration flows and the fear of Islamic radicalization, several Western countries have enacted policies to restrict religious expression and emphasize secularism and Western values. Despite intense public debate, there is little systematic evidence on how such policies influence the behavior of the religious minorities they target. In this paper, we use rich quantitative and qualitative data to evaluate the effects of the 2004 French headscarf ban on the socioeconomic integration of French Muslim women. We find that the law reduces the secondary educational attainment of Muslim girls and affects their trajectory in the labor market and family composition in the long run. We provide evidence that the ban operates through increased perceptions of discrimination and that it strengthens both national and religious identities.

FIGURE 1. Prevalence of Laws Regulating Veiling across Europe



Note: The figures describe the status of veiling laws. The left panel illustrates the prevalence of headscarf laws. The right panel maps the prevalence of full-face veil (burqa or niqab) laws. Laws include bans implemented in all public spaces or specific contexts such as schools or courts. "Local" and "national" refer to the level of government that implements the law. Data is from the European Commission (2017) and Open Society Foundations (2018).

Rates of Secondary Education Completion by Birth Cohort for French-Born Women

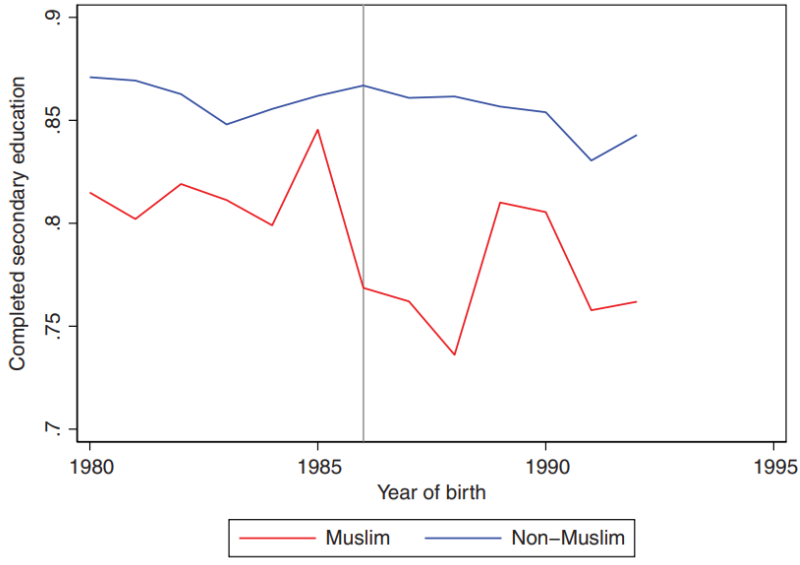
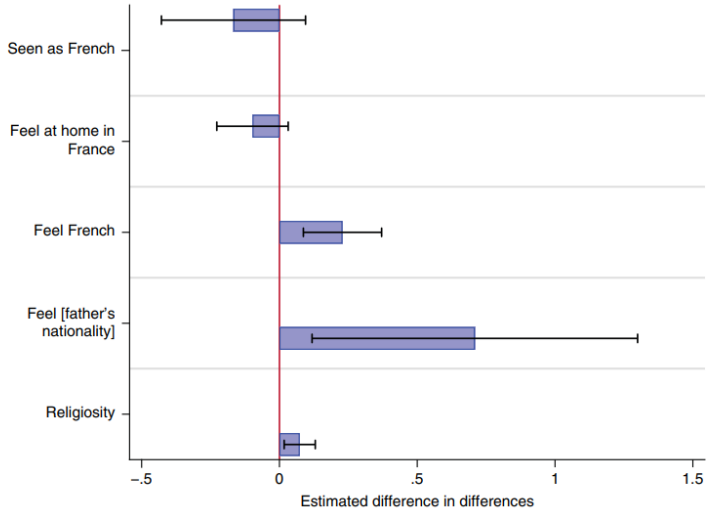
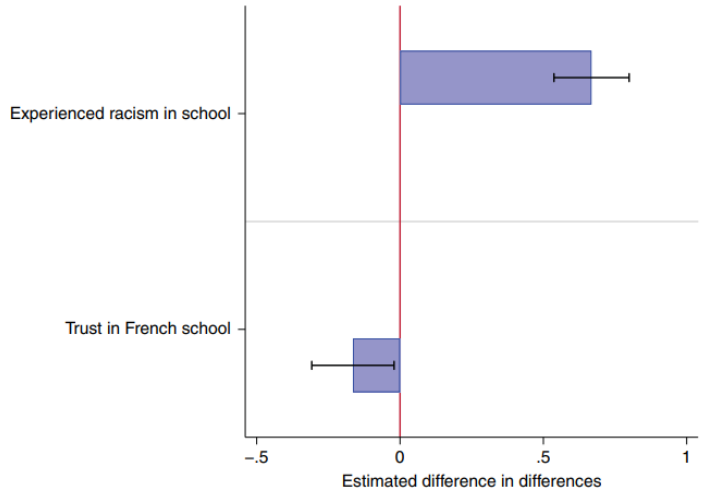


FIGURE 3. Effects on Self-Reported Measures of Identity



Note: The figure plots coefficient estimates and 90% confidence intervals from the interaction between Muslim religion and an indicator for individuals born after 1985. The regression controls for birth cohort and religion fixed effects, as well as for a linear Muslim-specific age trend. The sample consists of French-born women born 1980 or later. For all outcomes but religiosity the sample is restricted to women with foreign-born parents. Outcomes are standardized and estimated effects can be interpreted in terms of standard deviations.

FIGURE 4. Experiences in and Views of French School.



Note: The figure plots coefficient estimates and 90% confidence intervals from the interaction between Muslim religion and an indicator for individuals born after 1985. The regression controls for birth cohort and religion fixed effects, as well as for a linear Muslim-specific age trend. The sample consists of French-born women born 1980 or later. Outcomes are standardized and estimated effects can be interpreted in terms of standard deviations.

In this class

- Nations are recent and were **built**, largely through the school.
- Two routes to the nation-state: redraw the borders around the people, or remake the people inside the borders. France took the second.
- France: state-sponsored education moved everyday speech toward French, where local power had shifted and families wanted schooling.
- France again, today: banning the headscarf at school strengthened both identities instead of dissolving one.
- Same instrument, opposite results. What differs is who supplies the schooling, and whether the target has a choice.